would not offend foreigners by saying these things in their hearing, but many would hold to much of the Zhang formula privately. At any rate, here is another hierarchical view: China as the greatest power on earth, 'returning to the preeminent status it once enjoyed in the past' (in Zhang's categorical words) and unmatched in its super and unique features.[102] Chinese exceptionalism is reminiscent of American exceptionalism. Yet Americans could hardly claim to match China in terms of being the longest continuous civilization, the largest population, or the inventors of a unique language. China is, therefore, on this view, a very special superpower.

India in Chinese worldviews

India has a slightly different place in each of these Chinese worldviews, but what is constant is that it, as much of the world, is placed in a grid in which there are gradations and ranks. From a tianxia view, India is another smaller neighbour on the periphery of China. It is by far the largest of the 'smaller' neighbours, so it ranks above others in Asia, but it is a potential tributary. In a social setting, smaller entities must understand their place, which means knowing their entitlements and obligations. China too must comprehend its own size, entitlements, and obligations. Because China is the moral and political centre in a tianxia universe, those on the periphery including India would be drawn to it for protection and symbolic and material rewards. Historically, tributaries would send tributes or would personally appear to kowtow at the imperial court with their tributes in order to be recognized by the Son of Heaven, the Chinese emperor. They would bear gifts and submit to certain norms and obligations. The emperor would in return give personal gifts, trading rights within China and in the region, and protection against rivals, domestic and international. Tributaries are not humiliated or punished, unless they violate norms established in the relationship or fail to pay tribute. As the largest of China's Asian neighbours, India would qualify for somewhat different treatment from the treatment given to other tributaries. India–China relations might be marked by a special degree of